Invisible Pioneers: Exploring the Experiences of African American Female Athletes – A Digital Story

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Introduction

The history of African American women in sport has been neglected in the literature, especially in comparison to other groups that have made significant strides in sport. African American women in sport and physical activity have been largely overlooked by sport sociologists, especially their experiences during the late Civil Rights Era (Cain, 2000).

The lack of historical knowledge raises many multidisciplinary (e.g., sport sociology and sport psychology) questions including; What were the experiences of African American women pre-Title IX? How can these women's stories be documented? How has sports participation influenced the lives of the participants (e.g., career choices, educational goals, self-confidence)? How did race and race relations during the Civil Rights era influence their sports experiences?

This study focuses on six African American women who participated as high school and collegiate athletes toward the end of the Civil Rights era. Participants' sport experiences are intertwined and the women have formed a camaraderie that has been unbroken for over 30 years. Beyond simply recounting history, there has been very little research that documents the experiences of African American women in sport. This study allowed researchers to add to the knowledge base and present their unique stories–in the form of a digital story. The digital story is used to capture, accurately recount, and document personal experiences for future use.

Purpose

This research aims to uncover and begin to archive the experiences of African American female athletes and serve as a medium for public expression.

Study findings will provide information that can be used by educators, coaches, and nonprofit organizations to create programs that will benefit young minority women. Additionally, the digital story begins to acknowledge the different ways that individuals experience sport based on their cultural perspectives.

Participants

- Six African American women ages 49-64
- All grew up or moved to a major Metropolitan area in the Midwest

Procedure

Part 1: Focus Group

The six women participated in a focus group, in which they answered pre-determined, open-ended questions about their experiences in and relationships developed through sport. Elaboration and clarification probes were used when necessary. Examples of questions participants were asked include:

1.Can you tell me about your sport experiences in high school, college, and after college?
2. Can you talk about the role your family played in your participation?

Part 2: Individual Interview

After the focus group, each participant completed a semi-structured interview. Interviews were personalized to each participant based on answers from the focus group. Examples of the questions participants were asked include:

1.You called [community center] the heart of the community, what did you mean by that?
2.In the group interview, you said that, "I'm looking at being an athlete and being a woman of color athlete in Minnesota is a full time job." What did you mean by that?

Part 3: Digital Story

Based on data analysis of responses from the focus group and interviews, researchers formulated new questions to delve into each woman's individual experiences and the impact that her sport experiences had on her goals, educational pursuits, passions, and overall well-being. Examples of these questions include:

1.At what age did you begin playing sports? What sports did you participate in when you were younger?
2. Can you think of a place that has been influential in your sport experience? (i.e., recreation center or playground)

Responses to questions were recorded to aid in the telling of their personal sport and life experiences—in their voices. Participants also submitted pictures to go along with the story they were telling.

After creating a voice-over and collecting images, a researcher created a storyboard (see Figure 1), which depicted each video frame, the image that is displayed, the duration of the frame, and the soundtrack / voice-over. All of the images were complied and organized based on the storyboard. The final step was to use the software Final Cut to edit the digital story into a cohesive unit.

Figure 1. Example of the storyboard

Scene #1	Title	
Invisible Pioneers Exploring of African American Female Athletes During the Late Civil Rights Era	Location: Graphic Participants: None	Music: Mos Def – Respiration (Instrumental) Pictures: None Video Clip: Title Appears then an animation will come to brighten the screen Text: Invisible Pioneers
Sketch	Frame Desc	
Scene #2	Civil Rights Tribute	
Civil Rights Era (Date)	Location: Graphic Participants: None	
Sketch	Frame Desc	

Scene #1	Title	
	Location: Graphic Participants: Various images of Civil Rights Leaders and memorable moments during the Civil Rights Movement	Music: Kanye West and Jay-Z -Made in American featuring Frank Ocean Pictures: Various http://faithcenter.files.wordpress.com/2010/01/martin-luther-king-jr.jpg Video Clip: Transition through images Text: None
Sketch	Frame Description	Media List
Scene #2	Civil Rights Tribute	
The information depicted has been collected from a qualitative study done at the University of Minnesota... These are the untold stories of invisible pioneers	Location: Graphic Participants: None	Music: Mos Def – Respiration Instrumental Pictures: None Video Clip: Scrolling Text Text:
Sketch	Frame Description	Media List

Conclusions

- Digital story telling serves as a powerful and innovative avenue to tell stories of (invisible) pioneers, while retaining the integrity of personal experiences.
- This digital story brings experiences and history to life and fills a gap in what we know about African American women's experiences in sport.

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Photo Credit:
http://www.myblackhistory.net/Florence_Griffith_Joyner.htm

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